PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

The Siege of Petersburg — A House Divided

How War Itself Changed

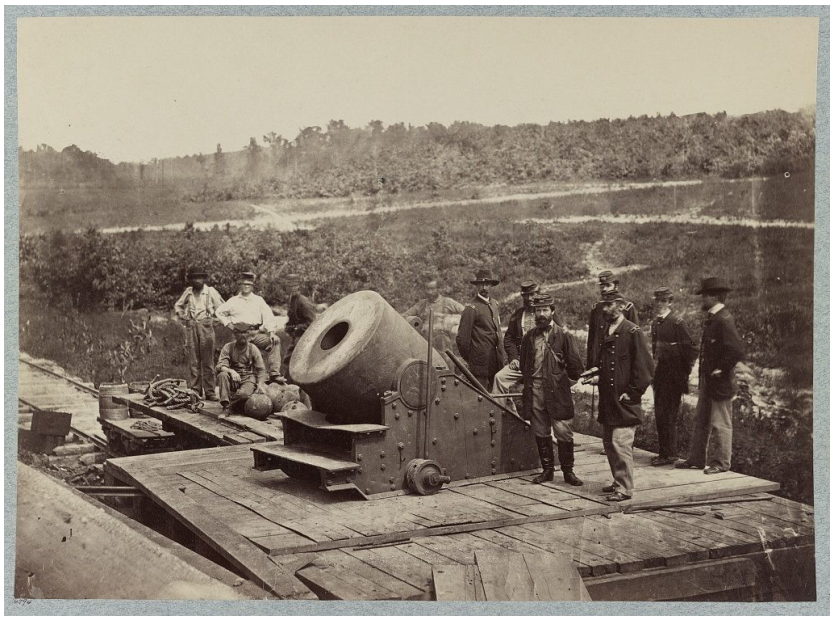
Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about The Siege of Petersburg — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Compare the beginning and the end. Name exactly what changed between 1861 and the trenches of Petersburg

THE SOURCES

THE IMAGE · 1864 — "The Dictator"



"The Dictator" — a 13-inch mortar on a railroad car before Petersburg, Virginia — photograph, 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

THE IMAGE · 1865 — The trench barriers



Earthworks and sharpened-log barriers — the same picture would describe the Western Front of World War I, fifty years later

Chevaux-de-frise before the Confederate works at Petersburg, Virginia — photograph, 1865, public domain (Library of Congress).

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · BEFORE AND AFTER

Describe how armies fought at the start of the war (think Bull Run: open fields, marching lines) versus at Petersburg (trenches, siege, heavy machinery). List at least two differences.

_____

_____

_____

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · WHY IT CHANGED

Why did soldiers start digging trenches instead of charging across open fields?

- ☐ A. they were bored
- ☐ B. modern rifles and artillery made open charges too deadly to survive
- ☐ C. trenches were faster
- ☐ D. the generals preferred it

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · THE FUTURE

Historians say Petersburg looked like a “preview” of World War I. Using the images, explain what about this fighting pointed to the future of warfare rather than the past.

_____

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · NAME THE CHANGE

In two or three sentences, describe the change over time the Civil War set in motion: what kind of warfare ended, and what kind began?

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — The Siege of Petersburg — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "At the start… At Petersburg…"

QUESTION 2: **Correct — B. modern rifles and artillery made open charges too deadly to survive**

Right. Rifled muskets and artillery made open charges deadly beyond anything earlier tactics assumed. Digging in was the only way to survive — so the front froze into a siege.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Petersburg pointed to the future because…"

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "The war saw the end of ___ and the beginning of ___."